



Skinner Legacies

Client Rights and Grievance Resolution Policy

Ohio Behavioral Health / Medicaid / CARF-Aligned Procedure

Policy Area	Client Rights / Quality / Compliance	Applies To	All Persons Served and All Personnel
Review Frequency	At least annually and upon regulatory change	Responsible Role	Client Advocate / Executive Leadership

Designated Client Advocate (Client Rights Officer):	Christopher Skinner, PhD
Location:	398 W. Bagley Rd. Suite 10 Berea, OH 44017
Telephone:	440-467-1555
Email:	info@skinnerlegacies.com
Hours of Availability:	Monday-Friday 9AM-5PM
Alternate/Trained Grievance Recipient:	Amber Skinner, CEO

1. Purpose

Skinner Legacies is committed to protecting the rights, dignity, autonomy, privacy, and safety of every person served. This policy establishes a fair, accessible, timely, confidential, and non-retaliatory process for receiving, investigating, resolving, documenting, trending, and responding to client grievances. The grievance process is intended to support resolution of concerns without interfering with a person's right to receive appropriate services or to contact an outside advocacy, regulatory, payer, or governmental organization.

2. Definitions

"Client Advocate" means the individual designated by Skinner Legacies with responsibility for ensuring compliance with the client rights and grievance process. This title has the same meaning as Client Rights Officer or Client Rights Specialist.

"Grievance" means a written complaint, initiated verbally or in writing by a person served or by another individual or provider on behalf of a person served, regarding the denial or abuse of a client right. Skinner Legacies may also process other significant complaints through this procedure when doing so provides the person with a clear and documented resolution process.

"Grievant" means the person served or the individual/provider filing the grievance on behalf of the person served.



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3. Right to File a Grievance and Protection From Retaliation

A person served has the right to file a grievance, to receive oral and written instructions explaining how to file, and to receive assistance in filing when requested. A person is not required to first confront or discuss the concern with the staff member involved. Informal resolution may be offered, but it is voluntary and will not be used to delay or prevent a formal grievance.

No person served, family member, representative, witness, or other individual will be threatened, intimidated, discriminated against, denied appropriate services, discharged, or otherwise retaliated against for raising a concern, filing a grievance, participating in an investigation, requesting assistance, or contacting an outside organization.

4. Accessibility and Assistance

Skinner Legacies will explain the grievance process in a manner appropriate to the person's age, developmental level, communication needs, language, disability, literacy, and ability to understand. Reasonable accommodations, language assistance, accessible formats, and assistance completing the grievance will be provided as needed.

At least one trained individual able to receive a grievance will be available on site during a core number of hours each day the office is open. The designated Client Advocate will be available on site or by approved virtual means for a core number of hours each week to assist with grievances. If virtual access is offered, a private space and necessary equipment will be made available at the Skinner Legacies location for a client who chooses that method.

5. How a Grievance May Be Submitted

A grievance may begin verbally or in writing and may be presented in person, by telephone, by mail, by email through an approved method, or by another accessible means made available by Skinner Legacies. A grievance may be given to the Client Advocate or to a trained staff member designated to receive grievances and promptly forward them to the Client Advocate.

A formal grievance must be reduced to writing. If the person makes the grievance verbally or is unable or does not wish to prepare the written grievance independently, the Client Advocate will prepare the written text and review it with the grievant for accuracy.

The written grievance will be dated and signed by the person served or the individual filing on the person's behalf. If a signature cannot reasonably be obtained, the Client Advocate may attest that the written grievance is a true and accurate representation of the grievance. The grievance should include, when available, the date and approximate time of the event, a description of what occurred, the names of individuals involved, the right or concern at issue, and the resolution requested.

Skinner Legacies will provide a confidential method for submitting grievances. Under the Ohio behavioral health grievance rule, a formal grievance is not anonymous; however, the grievance and investigation will be handled as confidentially as reasonably possible.

6. Receipt and Written Acknowledgment

The date Skinner Legacies first receives the verbal or written grievance will be treated as the date of receipt. The grievance will be forwarded promptly to the Client Advocate.



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Within three (3) business days of receipt, Skinner Legacies will provide the grievant with written acknowledgment containing at least:

- The date the grievance was received;
- A summary of the grievance;
- An overview of the investigation and resolution process;
- The anticipated timetable for investigation and written resolution; and
- The name, address, and telephone number of the Skinner Legacies contact responsible for the grievance.

7. Investigation

The Client Advocate will conduct or coordinate an impartial review of the grievance. To the extent practicable, an individual who is the subject of the grievance will not control the investigation or make the final resolution decision. When the Client Advocate is directly involved in the allegation or has a conflict of interest, Executive Leadership will assign an alternate qualified reviewer.

The investigation may include interviews with the grievant, staff, witnesses, family or representatives when authorized; review of the clinical record and relevant administrative records; review of policies, procedures, service requirements, communications, incident reports, or other evidence; consultation with clinical, compliance, legal, payer, or regulatory resources when appropriate; and immediate protective or corrective action when a health, safety, rights, or compliance concern requires action before the investigation is complete.

Only information reasonably necessary to investigate and resolve the grievance will be shared. Grievance information will be maintained separately or with restricted access as appropriate and will not be used for retaliation.

8. Resolution Timeframe

Skinner Legacies will make a grievance resolution decision and provide written notification of the resolution within twenty (20) business days of receipt of the grievance.

If extenuating circumstances make resolution within twenty business days impracticable, the circumstances and reason for the extension will be documented in the grievance file and written notice will be provided to the grievant. The notice will explain the reason for the extension and the anticipated completion date. Extensions will not be used routinely or to unnecessarily delay resolution.

9. Written Resolution

The written resolution will be understandable and will include, as appropriate, the issue reviewed, a summary of the review completed, the decision or findings, any remedy or corrective action that may appropriately be disclosed, and information regarding additional review or external grievance options. Confidential personnel information or protected information concerning another person will not be disclosed.

Possible remedies may include clarification or explanation, restoration or coordination of services, referral, corrective action, staff education or supervision, policy or workflow revision, accessibility



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improvements, communication changes, quality-improvement activity, or other action appropriate to the findings.

10. Internal Review / Reconsideration

If the grievant is dissatisfied with the Skinner Legacies resolution, the grievant may request an internal review by the Chief Operating Officer, Chief Executive Officer, or an uninvolved designee. The request may be verbal or written, and the Client Advocate will assist when requested. The internal review will not restrict or delay the grievant's right to contact an outside organization at any time.

Any internal reconsideration will be handled as promptly as possible and, when feasible, within the original twenty-business-day grievance resolution period. If additional time is necessary, the extension requirements in this policy apply.

11. External Grievance and Advocacy Options

A person served may contact an outside organization at any time and is not required to complete the Skinner Legacies grievance process before doing so unless a particular external appeal process has its own exhaustion requirement. Skinner Legacies will provide reasonable assistance locating the applicable county board or payer contact.

Applicable Alcohol, Drug Addiction and Mental Health Services Board (ADAMHS/MHRS Board): Contact information will be provided based on the person's county of residence or applicable board service area.

Ohio Department of Behavioral Health: 30 East Broad Street, 36th Floor, Columbus, Ohio 43215; 877-275-6364 or 614-466-7228.

Disability Rights Ohio: Attn: Intake, 200 Civic Center Drive, Suite 300, Columbus, Ohio 43215; 614-466-7264 or 800-282-9181.

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Office for Civil Rights - Midwest Region: John C. Kluczynski Federal Building, 230 S. Dearborn St., Chicago, IL 60604; 800-368-1019; TDD 800-537-7697.

12. Medicaid Managed Care Grievances and Appeals

The Skinner Legacies grievance process does not replace a Medicaid member's grievance, appeal, or state-hearing rights. A Medicaid member may contact the member's Medicaid managed care entity, MyCare Ohio plan, OhioRISE plan, or other applicable payer regarding dissatisfaction with quality, access, interpersonal treatment, coverage, authorization, reduction, suspension, termination, payment, or another matter within the payer's grievance or appeal jurisdiction.

When a concern involves an adverse benefit determination, such as a denial or limitation of authorization, reduction, suspension or termination of a previously authorized service, untimely authorization decision, or denial of payment that affects the member, personnel will direct the member to the appeal rights and deadlines contained in the payer's notice of action/adverse benefit determination. Skinner Legacies will not mischaracterize a payer appeal as an internal



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agency grievance or allow the internal grievance process to cause a member to miss a payer or state-hearing deadline.

Upon request and when permitted, Skinner Legacies personnel may assist the member in understanding payer grievance/appeal information, obtaining records, contacting the payer, or participating in the process within the provider's permitted role.

13. Immediate Safety, Abuse, Neglect, Exploitation, Privacy, or Compliance Concerns

A grievance that contains allegations of abuse, neglect, exploitation, sexual misconduct, imminent risk, discrimination, fraud, privacy/security breach, or another reportable or urgent event will be handled under this grievance policy and also immediately routed through any applicable incident-reporting, mandatory-reporting, compliance, privacy, safety, licensing, payer, or law-enforcement process. The grievance process will not delay mandatory reporting or immediate protective action.

14. Documentation and Record Retention

Skinner Legacies will maintain a grievance file that includes, at minimum, a copy of the grievance; the written acknowledgment; documentation of the investigation process; relevant correspondence; the resolution/remedy; any internal review; and documentation of extenuating circumstances and extension notices when applicable.

Ohio's behavioral health grievance rule requires grievance records to be maintained for at least two years from resolution. Skinner Legacies will use a longer organizational retention standard and retain grievance records for at least seven (7) years from final resolution, unless a longer period is required by law, contract, audit, litigation hold, investigation, payer requirement, or another Skinner Legacies records-retention requirement.

Grievance records will be secured and accessed only by authorized personnel. Information necessary for treatment or safety may be documented in the clinical record when clinically appropriate, but the grievance investigation file itself will not routinely be placed in the clinical record.

15. Trending, Quality Improvement, and Leadership Oversight

Leadership will review grievance information in aggregate to identify recurring concerns, rights issues, service barriers, access problems, communication concerns, workforce training needs, safety risks, and opportunities for performance improvement. Grievance trends may be incorporated into quality improvement, risk management, program planning, workforce development, strategic planning, and corrective-action activities. Aggregate review will protect client confidentiality.

Leadership will periodically evaluate the effectiveness and timeliness of the grievance process, including acknowledgment and resolution timeframes, outcomes, patterns, and corrective actions.

16. Posting, Distribution, and Staff Training

The Client Rights Policy and this grievance procedure will be posted conspicuously at each Skinner Legacies-controlled service location in an area accessible to persons served,



families/significant others, and the public. They will also be posted conspicuously on the Skinner Legacies website together with the Client Advocate's name, telephone number, and email address.

When Skinner Legacies provides services at a location it does not control and posting is not feasible, copies will be available to any person who requests them.

All employees, contractors, volunteers, and student interns are expected to follow the Client Rights Policy and grievance procedure. Skinner Legacies will document in each applicable personnel file that the individual received the policies and agreed to abide by them. Orientation and ongoing training will include client rights and grievance responsibilities.

17. Non-Interference With Care

Filing a grievance will not, by itself, interrupt medically necessary or otherwise appropriate services. Any change in services will be based on clinical, safety, eligibility, authorization, payer, or other legitimate requirements and will be documented independently of the grievance. A grievance will never be used as the basis for retaliation or punitive discharge.

18. Policy Review

Executive Leadership and the Client Advocate will review this policy at least annually and whenever relevant Ohio behavioral health, Medicaid, federal civil-rights, accreditation, payer, or organizational requirements change. External contact information and posted Client Advocate information will be verified during the review.

19. References

- Ohio Administrative Code Rule 5122-26-18, Client rights and grievance procedure (effective August 1, 2026).
- Ohio Administrative Code Chapter 5122-26, including personnel orientation and client-rights requirements.
- Ohio Administrative Code Rule 5160-26-08.4, Managed care: appeal and grievance system.
- Ohio Administrative Code Rule 5160-58-08.4, Grievances, appeals, and state fair hearings for MyCare Ohio.
- 42 C.F.R. Part 438, Subpart F, as applicable to Medicaid managed care.
- CARF Behavioral Health accreditation standards applicable to rights of persons served, complaints/grievances, accessibility, quality improvement, and performance management.